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CULTURE

Tokyo Thrift: Embracing the Strange Individualisation of the Sustainable Fashion Problem

On why blaming the individual consumer for fast fashion's damage is a structural trap — and what a more honest, less guilt-driven approach to sustainable choices might actually look like when the industry's harms are genuinely systemic.

BY DHAIRYA MISHRA

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ABOUT

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The Truth Takes Time.

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Think about it, fast fashion is like fast food. It might be cheaper at a time, but absurdly more expensive & wasteful put together during long-term expenditures, thereby trapping lower income groups in a vicious cycle that coerces them to take part in the very consumption patterns that drain them, both ethically & financially.

DHAIRYA MISHRA, UNITING FOR A SUSTAINABLE FASHION FUTURE: THE POWER OF COLLECTIVE ACTION

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"We do not need a handful of people doing zero waste perfectly. We need millions of people doing it imperfectly."

ANNE MARIE BONNEAU, ZERO WASTE CHEF

On derationalising the guilt of individual consumption & finding the middle ground between waiting around for big changes & making small ones happen.

The ugly truth of fast fashion hides behind the glitter and glamour of the social media posts of a generation that does not wish to repeat an outfit. The OOTD (Outfit of the Day) is turning into DOTD (Disaster of the Decade) (I think I'm funny).

Point is, it becomes harder to overlook the unpleasant reality of something, anything, when you learn a bit about it. There is a call coming from inside the house - or dare I say, factory - that is the fashion industry right now, loud & clear; a dire need for reform, whether it be of the exploitation of labourers or underage workers or the brutalisation of our environment & wildlife.

Imagine a little child toiling away in a factory for long hours under OSHA-certified 'hazardous' conditions, in order to satisfy *your* need for quick & cheap clothes. Consider the degree of damage caused when plastic waste from polyester factories enters the stomachs of threatened sea turtles. The impact that our choices in clothing have on the world around us is heartbreaking.

But they are *choices*, after all. We can always make different ones.

First: Scrap the Guilt

There's a debate to be had here, of course, about the weight of the world being shifted from turrets of the multibillion-dollar conglomerates that are running it to the shoulders of individual men & women who've been done the mercy of being allowed to exist in it (conditionally). And it is an important one.

Our sociological collective has a problem with denialism, of shifting blame from all the places it need to be back to the unitary, powerless individual that doesn't even have the authority to refuse it. And I do wish it goes to therapy sometime soon, for its sake if not mine, but it doesn't change the fact that something is better than nothing, & for the while that Gates & Bezos refuse to do their parts, I would like to do something other than crying with my thumb up my ass.

So there's the (multi)billion-dollar question: if it comes down to it, is there a way for us puny, insignificant, middle-class individuals to undo, even in fraction, some of the damage that's being done to the bigger picture? *You're one microscopic cog in his catastrophic plan, designed & directed by his red right hand*, yada yada, understood. Is there a way, at least, for us to wash our hands clean?

The answer is yes. Always has been. Truth is, we have power as customers, a lot of power. Power enough to not just make a dent, but hell, force a remodel on the whole goddamn lineup. In this article, I've compiled a few simple consumer choices that might be a good place to start.

Rich Dad Poor Dad

Of course, one of the larger ways in which a consumer can exercise supposed 'agency' in the market, is his investment choices; & the implication here should be clear enough: if you don't have capital to invest, you don't have capital to make ethical decisions. Beggars, choosers, & all that jazz. So another requisite to understand here, as will be discussed below, is privilege. The obligation to make good choices as a consumer comes with what is first, the privilege to make choices at all. So it should be understood hereon that advice on where within the fashion sector you should invest & on what is less Rich Dad Poor Dad finance guru talk & more The Good Place perspectives on ethical consumption.

<https://www.instagram.com/reel/C4wHtaQyMOu/?igsh=NH13MjB3NzA0ZjM5>

In the above video, climate activist, Michael Mezzatesta (@michael_mezz on Instagram) counters the popular & controversial capitalist defense, "wealth is not a zero-sum game" by paraphrasing what is also one of its most popular critiques: imagined wealth may not be zero-sum, but the resources required to generate & maintain it are.

BAD ADVICE CAN BE GOOD ADVICE

Start by deciding on eco-friendly and sustainable materials that are less or just not harmful to the environment, such as organics like cotton, hemp, or recycled textiles. It may sound elementary, but sticking it out with the good old organics can be a deceptively effective way to decrease one's reliance on quick fashion. Think about how many t-shirts you've gone through in the last 5 years versus how many your parents did when you were growing up. How many did your grandparents? A good organic polyblend will *last longer*; the point of buying a 1000-dollar jacket may not be a wise expenditure in any economic pool of thought outside of Shark Tank, but it can be to minimize the resources exhausted in the making of the alternative five.

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If you've got the money, eat a salad, & wear cotton, not only because you can, but because doing so is the only way to ensure you won't need to down the line, either. There's many a survivor of unHappy meals who will resent you a little less for using your privilege right.

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CHECKING YOUR INVESTMENTS: 5 MINUTE CRAFTS

One way to determine whether a piece is a good investment or not is to use the "30 wears rule". It is a calculation that can be used to judge whether an item is a wise purchase. Simply ask yourself if you can envision yourself wearing an item at least 30 times before you buy it. And that's not quite so simple as taking a second look & saying, 'Ah! no sweat.' When the rule says 30 times, it *means* 30 times. Think of thirty different combinations, thirty different pairings, thirty different hairstyles, thirty different occasions, thirty different possible event locations for said occasions (& whether they match the vibe).

Thirty different audiences & thirty different *looks* for them to look at. And if all that sounds like a bit much, throw it back in the bin.

If you get bored even thinking about it thirty times, you have no business taking it home.

Werk, bitch.

Not only should we choose our clothing carefully, but we need to style it well. Yes, you heard that right, all those Pinterest style videos pinned up on your autumn aesthetics board & Instagram style reels clogging up your saves are weapons in your climate fashion war & a soft cottage core girl will inherit the earth. Keep up.

Jokes aside, it's important to remember that the villain is not fashion here. The villain is industry. The villain is mass production without regulation, & mass consumption without thought. When the title says sustainable fashion, it does still mean fashion. Reread the first section again if you must, but don't forget, you are not where the blame lies. If the world goes down in flames 5 decades from now it will not be because a young girl with seemingly vain tastes wanted to dress up cute.

Your joys are not killing the world. You can want to look good, & you can want to spend time & resources on doing so. But being thoughtful about techniques can help minimise the amount of resources that go to waste, & the argument becomes simple: if your looks are entirely dependent on the money you spend on them, you're not fashionable, you're just rich.

A single article of clothing can be dressed in a variety of ways to produce various looks, which can help the garment last longer and decrease waste. The point is, you don't have to look up a list of sustainable fashion influencers to be sustainable, even just putting a bit more effort into doing fashion right can be sustainable.

Tokyo Thrift: Macklemore Them Tags

It doesn't need to be said, but this article will ring hollow without it, so I'll repeat: thrifting is god. Buying used items not only saves money but also decreases the impact that garment production has on the environment. And the chances of finding something irreplaceable at a thrift store are way higher than if you're buying off the rack.

For the Indian audience reading this, grow up. It's already been established that the target readership of this article are those, even in India, who seek or lead first-world lives, & find with them, first-world problems. Get real. This is not New York, there are no Goodwills here, & it will not drop you down four class brackets to shop at one if there were. *H&M* & *Zara* are not high society, they're just western. Even the taxpayers here shop at Sarojini. 'Thrifting' is not a subculture but *theculture*, & Sarojini is not the only market. Just take a mom friend with you.

Swades

If you happen to be one of those people who are under the sad, sad, belief that what does not come expensive is not worth owning, you probably won't be reading this article, you pretentious, stupid prick there is one place you can spend that sweet zero sum money, money, money on worthwhile products without paying the price in blood or carbon: go indigenous.

A simple but mostly expensive method to support sustainable fashion is purchasing Indian artisanal clothing, which not only supports Indian craftspeople but also encourages sustainable and environmentally good practices. Unfortunately, Indian materials, contrary to India's popular global identity as poverty-central, are consistently expensive. Silk, jute & khadi are millimeters away from being luxury goods in their pricing, but part of the reason for this is that their extraction occurs in wholly eco-friendly ways, which is the diplomatic way of saying hard, human labour. The starting range for cotton sarees at Khadi India is about Rs. 15,000, not only because the labour & craftsmanship that goes into them is leagues beyond that of say, a factory-produced shein dress, but because the price of that Shein dress is low because of a little something called *slavery*.

Sadly, India's central Khadi distributing corporation, KVIC (Khadi and Village Industries Commission), which oversees the Khadi India Brand, does not maintain transparency regarding its finances, & therefore, its labour treatment. A press release last year^[1] from the Press Information Bureau reported an astounding 332% sales growth over the past 10 years, & is a document of many other similar statistics that do seem to merit celebration. But the lack of objectivity in the release makes it read more like a promotional flyer than a formal report, & a complete omission of all information regarding revenue distribution & an outline of resource channels makes it so the information you can really get about their business is that it's doing well, as opposed to how. Nevertheless, it can be inferred, from the significantly costlier pricing & the fact that it is after all, a state initiative, that workers down to the grassroots level still find better, if not entirely fair compensation. This is already more than can be said about most foreign MNCs (*cough* Nestle *cough*).

Conclusion

Congratulations, you made it. So, to conclude, depending on where in the world it is that you're shopping, it can be more or less sustainable to buy expensive *or* cheap. (Fascinating how that can happen. It's almost as if one needs to look at who one is paying & what for, along with how much.)

*It's important to understand that the key takeaway here is not to consume in a way that is completely ethical (if you've either seen *The Good Place* or studied higher economics, (two equivalent philosophical qualifications) you might be familiar with the fact that that isn't quite possible) but simply more ethical than all viable alternatives.*

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^[1] press release last year